PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota 4Runner 4th Gen

2003–2009 · N210 · 1GR-FE · 2UZ-FE

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Frame rust**
  Not as notorious as contemporary Tacomas, but salt-belt trucks rot. Inspect the rails, crossmembers and rear suspension link mounts with a hammer and a light — and note the 4Runner wasn't part of Toyota's Tacoma/Tundra/Sequoia frame programmes.
- [ ] **V8 air-injection pump and manifolds**
  CarComplaints owners report the V8's secondary air injection system failing around 100,000–150,000 miles, triggering a check-engine light and limp mode, with $2,000–4,000 repair bills. Cold-start ticking can be a leaking exhaust manifold, which on the V8 is integrated with the catalytic converters.
- [ ] **V8 timing belt records**
  The 2UZ-FE has a timing belt (the V6 has a chain). Toyota's maintenance guide lists replacement at 90,000 miles or 108 months (as summarised by Cherish Your Car); LC Engineering suggests inspecting from about 60,000 and doing the water pump at the same time. No records means budget for it.
- [ ] **V6 coolant loss**
  2003–05 V6s are the ones Autotrader says report head-gasket failures more than average, and forum owners point to 2003–04 in particular; a cylinder 6 misfire (P0306) plus coolant loss is the red flag. Check the overflow level, watch a cold start, and consider a combustion-gas test.
- [ ] **X-REAS and rear air springs**
  X-REAS shocks leak and rust with age and TacomaWorld members note they're replaced in pairs at real cost. On Limiteds with rear height control, check the rear doesn't sag overnight. Either can be converted to conventional parts.
- [ ] **Brake actuator**
  Listen with the engine running: a TacomaWorld member found the ABS accumulator pump cycling every 30 seconds with pedal vibration on one test truck — a sign the actuator is on its way out.
- [ ] **Steering, CVs and bushings**
  Turn to full lock and look for a wet inner rack boot (fluid seeping into it damages the inner joint), torn CV boots past 100,000 miles, and clunky front sway-bar bushings.
- [ ] **Dash and interior**
  Cracked dashboards were common enough that Toyota's ZE6 warranty enhancement covered 2003–2005 4Runners, but that coverage has long since lapsed. Check that the third-row seat, power rear window and interior lights all work.

YEARS TO KNOW

2003–05	BEWARE	V6 head gaskets: Autotrader says failures on 2003–05 V6s are reported more than average, and Expedition Portal owners put most of them in 2003–04. Wikipedia dates the revised gasket to late in the 2006 model year

2006	SWEET SPOT	Mid-cycle refresh: new bumpers and grille, projector headlamps, LED tail lamps. HotCars picks the 2006-on V8 trucks as the better buys, and late-2006 V6s get the revised head gasket

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Fuel pulsation damper leak (V6)**
  2003 · NHTSA 03V-146
- ☐ **Port-installed alloy wheel upgrade**
  2003 · NHTSA 02V-339
- ☐ **Floor mat pedal entrapment**
  2003–2009 · NHTSA 11V-113
- ☐ **Side curtain airbag inadvertent deployment**
  2004–2006 · NHTSA 16V-065

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Model codes**
  US trucks are GRN210/215 (4.0 1GR-FE V6) or UZN210/215 (4.7 2UZ-FE V8).
- ☐ **4WD system**
  V8 4WD trucks are full-time; V6 trucks are part-time or Multi-Mode. Both use a lockable Torsen centre diff.
- ☐ **Trail Edition (2009)**
  The only 4th gen with a factory rear e-locker, plus an A-TRAC switch and Bilstein dampers. Check for the locker switch before paying a Trail premium.
- ☐ **X-REAS and rear air**
  X-REAS cross-linked dampers were standard on the Sport Edition and optional elsewhere; some Limiteds also have rear height-adjustable air suspension. Both are costly to replace like-for-like.
- ☐ **Pre- or post-facelift**
  2006-on trucks have round fog lamps with the turn signals in the headlamps, projector headlamps and LED tail lamps.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/4runner/4th-gen/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks